

Counting on a vacation to turn how you've been feeling around

8 findings · 10-step checklist · 1 myth · 5 sources · [cheatgrid.com](#)

Memory improves a trip after you're home, so the version you'll carry is better than the ordinary days you're in now. A trip also **can't lift a mood** that was already low.

THE GOAL

You're working out what's flattening you this week, rather than grading the trip. Name the one specific thing behind it, like a deadline or an empty fridge.

CHECKLIST

The first time you catch yourself feeling back to normal, flat you, and start wondering whether the trip actually did anything.

- ☐ Name the one specific thing making you feel flat right now, like a deadline or an empty fridge, instead of blaming the whole trip.
- ☐ If backlog work or chores are pulling on you right now, **clear the single most overdue item** before you judge the trip.
- ☐ Check whether it was the week before you left, not the trip itself, that actually felt like the hard part.
- ☐ If the week before you left was the hard part, name the one task that ate it, like a handoff or last-minute packing.
- ☐ Write down two or three specific moments from the trip, like a meal or a view, while they're still sharp.
- ☐ If someone asks how the trip was, name one thing you'd repeat and one you wouldn't, instead of just saying 'good' or 'fine.'
- ☐ Rate how relaxed the trip itself actually felt, not how long it was or how far you went, and write that down.
- ☐ If the good feeling has faded, write down one thing from the trip you'd book again, instead of re-checking whether you picked right.
- ☐ Pick one evening or a weekend slot on your calendar right now and mark it **'no work.'**
- ☐ If you're already eyeing next year's dates, choose several smaller trips through the year or one big one, based on how relaxed this trip felt.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 How many trips you take, or how long they are, will **never fix** a mood that's already low.
- 2 A trip you'd call 'relaxed' gave no lift once people got home. Only 'very relaxed' did.
- 3 You'll likely remember this trip as better than it actually felt at the time. That's just what memory does to a vacation.

What actually moves the needle, and what doesn't

KNOW

How many trips you take, or how long they are, will **never fix** a mood that's already low.

People tracked over time didn't get happier from taking more trips or longer ones. [Source 1](#)

DO

The only way to get more out of vacationing is to take it more often, since trip size doesn't move your overall mood either way. Spreading trips through the year gives you more short lifts than saving everything for one big one.

Saving up for one big trip only gives you one short lift, where several smaller trips give you several. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

A trip you'd call 'relaxed' gave no lift once people got home. Only 'very relaxed' did.

Merely feeling 'relaxed' on a trip produced no measurable lift once people were back home. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

A trip's mood boost fades once you're home. That's what **most** good trips do, not proof you picked wrong.

People's trip-related mood boost faded once they were back in their normal routine and workload. [Source 3](#)

The real reason the run-up feels bad

KNOW

Your well-being usually holds steady for the first week of the countdown, then dips again in the final week before you leave.

Workers surveyed reported a small but real dip in well-being between the two-week and one-week mark before their trip. [Source 4](#)

WATCH

What drags you down before a trip is the workload you're racing to clear, not the excitement of going.

The same workers' anticipation scores didn't predict their well-being, but their workload scores did. [Source 4](#)

The gap between what you felt and what you'll remember

KNOW

You'll likely remember this trip as better than it actually felt at the time. That's just what memory does to a vacation.

People kept diaries of a trip and rated their enjoyment higher afterward than they had rated it at the time. [Source 5](#)

DO

A little downtime in the weeks right after you're back protects the trip's lift longer than skipping it does. People who kept some relaxation time going lost the good feeling more slowly.

Teachers who used spare evenings and weekends to relax **kept feeling the trip's benefit longer** than the rest. [Source 5](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

A longer trip resets you more than a short one does.

ACTUALLY

How long a trip lasted made **no measurable difference at all** to how happy people felt once they were back home. [Source 2](#)

Sources

1. <https://repub.eur.nl/pub/31164/>
2. <http://www2.eur.nl/fsw/research/veenhoven/Pub2010s/2010g-full.pdf>
3. https://www.jstage.jst.go.jp/article/joh/51/1/51_K8004/_article
4. <https://research.rug.nl/en/publications/pre-vacation-time-blessing-or-burden>
5. <https://www.bps.org.uk/psychologist/wish-you-were-here>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Free time and rest at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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